

THE USES OF HISTORY: DELIBERATIVE ANALOGY AND VICTOR DAVIS HANSON

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The bombings of the last two weeks have raised a number of analogies with wars of the past — nearly all of them false and, in fact, dangerous. – Victor Davis Hanson

A common trope in political discourse, from the founding of the American republic, has been the use of historical analogies as a means of legitimation; the classics in particular have been used as a model and bellwether for the American political experience. One political commentator who uses history in political discourse is Victor Davis Hanson, a senior fellow at Stanford's Hoover Institute. Hanson is trained as a classicist and has written a number of books and articles on classical subjects, most recently *A War Like No Other: How the Athenians and Spartans Fought the Peloponnesian War* (2005). He is most well known, however, for his writing on contemporary political questions. Hanson is a syndicated columnist for the Tribune News Service and is a regular contributor for the *National Review*. This combination of interests creates for Hanson as a unique perspective in his regular op-ed contributions.

This paper considers how Hanson uses classical history as a source of authority, particularly through the device of analogy. Specifically, I argue that Hanson (mis)represents historical facts to validate his neo-conservative positions. This practice allows Hanson to assume a position of authority because his average reader has little knowledge of the historical facts Hanson is referencing. Hanson uses classical history as rhetorical legitimation. Thomas Farrell's conception of social knowledge will

serve as a foundation for understanding how Hanson uses history to gain authority for his arguments. According to Farrell (1982), there are two basic categories of knowledge, social and technical. Social knowledge implies consensus, the information imparted by rhetorical appeals to commonalities in the audience (Farrell, 1982). Technical knowledge is employed by people within a community who have extensive knowledge of a subject, using complex jargon that is inaccessible to outsiders. This thesis will argue that Hanson's extensive use of historical analogy conflates technical and social knowledge. This conflation is achieved by continued use of classical history in rhetorical situations that call for social knowledge, when in fact the referents for the analogy are technical knowledge. The consensus is not a commonality of knowledge about ancient history, but rather the authority provided by seemingly neutral idea of history. History in this understanding is universally valid, immutable and static. Yet, history is none of these things. As with any cultural signifier, there are mythologies that appeal to multiple authorities and signifieds. Hanson's writing is uniquely coded because the analogies he uses are largely opaque to his audience. This usage is intriguing since we commonly view metaphor and analogy as a means for simplification and clarification. This coding both allows Hanson to garner legitimation from his position of authority as a classical scholar and constrains debate on his positions. I argue that Hanson's work is an example of how analogy in a deliberative context may become counter-productive to oppositional argument in the public sphere.

In fact, Hanson (2001) was catapulted to a wide audience when immediately prior to September 11, 2001 he published his book *Carnage and Culture*, examining the importance of leadership in times of conflict. The relevance of this publication after September 11th gave him prominence as a commentator on national news shows. He was soon awarded a regular column in the right leaning news magazine *The National Review*. Hanson's clear and precise prose quickly made him one of the most widely known classicists in America. *The Daily Telegraph* (2005) has called him America's "celebrity classicist" and his website claims

that he has been published in sources as diverse as *The New York Times* and *The Washington Times*. Hanson is also widely sought in the publishing world. For his latest book *A War like No Other* he received an advance of \$500,000 called “unprecedented” in classical scholarship by the *Los Angeles Times*. According to Francois Debrix (2005), Hanson’s work “is meant to have a very high populist appeal” (p. 1163). Hanson has risen to the national stage despite the abstruse nature of his specialization.

Hanson’s columns focus not on classical topics, but on terrorist attacks of September 11th, the American response, the war in Iraq and other very topical and relevant issues in national political discourse. In these columns, Hanson frequently cites ancient sources and classical history to “document” his arguments, but rarely makes arguments solely about classical history. However, his writing as a pundit would not be as relevant without his historical viewpoint.

Hanson quickly became a favorite of the Bush administration. Barry Gewen (2003) of the *New York Times* reported that Vice President Dick Cheney cited Hanson as “reflecting his own philosophy.” Cheney has quoted Hanson in speeches and reportedly encouraged his staff to read Hanson’s work. Hanson was also a consultant for the Pentagon Office of Net Assessment and was repeatedly invited to the White House and referred to as Bush’s favorite historian (Meyerson, 2005). Hanson’s relevance to the White House and its allies is striking given that his classicist training is very distinct from the military or political consultants that the Bush administration typically called upon. The influence of Hanson, relying on his arguments from ancient history, makes this essay noteworthy, particularly given the gravity of the policy decisions that Hanson endorsed. It is important to understand how Hanson’s use of history authorized him to join the small group of people who shaped the Bush administration’s policies.

Social Knowledge and Analogy

The starting point is social knowledge, particularly in the context of deliberative public rhetoric. Deliberative rhetoric is

concerned with public decision making in the present and the future. In this context, history traditionally functions as a guide for the present. The philosophy of history has been considered by some of the most esteemed philosophers from Hegel to Nietzsche to Foucault and others. The use of history as a trope in deliberative rhetoric is in itself a means of legitimation. That is, historical knowledge lends authority to those who deploy it in the public sphere, by the singular virtue that it is historical knowledge. I argue that historians employ a type of technical knowledge and when this knowledge is used in public discourse it allows historical knowledge to become “neutral facts,” legitimizing any number of arguments. Technical knowledge, as Farrell (1978) argues, can stifle public debate (p. 330). Historical technical knowledge because of its legitimation and remoteness from public life allows even less intervention from the public. The use of historical knowledge is comparatively inaccessible for public deliberation, a limitation; particularly compounded when evoking distanced classical history.

Analogy is a common means of using historical “fact” to argue about the present. Analogical reasoning and argument are a “whole family of arguments that assert important similar or dissimilar relationships between two or more persons, places, things, or events in order to support a disputable position” (Gronbeck, 1998). Analogy is not the only means by which this kind of historical argument is deployed. The use of historical events to argue about the present in deliberative context certainly lends itself to analogical reasoning. This understanding of analogical reasoning, in combination with the discussion of social knowledge and historicism brings us to a larger argument. The use of analogical reasoning is a deterministic frame, lending legitimization and deflecting criticism.

Starting in his article “Knowledge, Consensus and Rhetorical Theory,” Farrell (1976) makes the case for a pragmatic conception of “social knowledge” as a basis for rhetoric. Social knowledge is consensus driven; Farrell (1976) argues “(s)ocial knowledge must presume or attribute a consensus concerning the generalizable interest of persons in order that argument may

culminate in the advocacy of choice and action” (p. 7). The public must have a basic understanding of the concepts and terms in a rhetorical act for it to be persuasive in deliberation.

Technical knowledge is opposed to social knowledge in its basic lack of broad consensus on the terms and issues involved; “‘technical’ knowledge is grounded upon a consensus removed from public scrutiny” (Farrell, 1978, p. 330). For example, a climatologist making an argument about the necessity of emissions reductions might use technical terms in describing global warming. If the public has no means to judge the reliability of the terms, technical knowledge excludes non-specialists from meaningful public discourse. Technical knowledge crowds out the function of social knowledge in creating discussion and is often appropriated into the public sphere, as it is with Hanson. Goodnight (1982) elaborates that “argument practices arising from the personal and technical spheres presently substitute the semblance of deliberative discourse for actual deliberation, thereby diminishing public life” (p. 215).

History, as a trope, is itself a means of garnering authority. Authority and legitimation of history as a trope are important means by which the historical-deliberative analogy garners force in argument. Authority, construed rhetorically, is the ability of a person making an argument or claim to make their position more powerful on the basis of the form rather than the content of the message. According to Farrell (1982), authority is “grounded through its social-knowledge base” (p. 135). This point is well taken; social knowledge is relevant not only to the content of the speech, but also to the form. The form of a text can include the identity of the speaker, where it is presented and the type of argument that is used (among other things). The simple fact that historical material is being presented is a means of legitimation. History, as a trope, is a discourse that carries significant authority. History qua historical discourse creates historical narratives that form our cultural understanding of history. Kammen (1991) explains that “myths may be activated or reactivated in order to legitimize a version of history that is useful or attractive...mythic history...may be mobilized to bolster a traditional order on the

basis of a distant past” (p. 17). Further, Barthes (1997) makes the argument that historical discourse creates a “realistic effect” that allows historical discourse to develop authority simply by asserting that “it happened” (p. 122). The authority given to historical “facts” is culturally constructed. This cultural power is related in two ways to Farrell’s conception of social knowledge. First, the authority of history is garnered through social knowledge. The public widely accepts the “immortality of facts.” More importantly, this cultural power and authority then reshapes social knowledge about certain historical discourses. Discourse that relies on history, although it could be largely fabricated, is largely viewed as authoritative on the basis that is history.

The use of history configures a manner of thinking that Hayden White labels “historical knowledge.” This knowledge for White (1987) is characterized by its narrativity and its literary qualities. The key question is how history as a discourse is formulated as a narrative, with intent to tell a specific story about the past. Narratives about the past, for White, allow for the mythic and realistic effects of history to take full force. The narrativization of history is not neutral, but rather serves particular political and ideological ends. History, in the same way that a novel might employ narrative, is a particular way of telling and that method itself allows historical discourse to become more culturally powerful, simply by nature of being history (White, 1987). I will label Hanson’s use of history historical deliberative analogy. This type of analogical reasoning cannot help but function as a narrative. White (1987) explains how using the past to argue about the present functions as a narrative: “(a)ccording to this view of history as communication, a history is conceived to a ‘message’ about a ‘referent’ (the past, historical events, and so on) the content of which is both ‘information’ (the ‘facts’) and an explanation (the ‘narrative account’)” (p. 40). Historical deliberative analogy is then a particular kind of analogy that asserts causality for its referent. This type of discourse inevitably contains the ideological subtexts that are obscured by the legitimization native to historical narratives.

Hanson relies on history as legitimization. In his writing he also uses a particular logic to connect history to the present, that is,

analogy. Rhetorical scholars have frequently considered how metaphors shape and frame public policy discourse. Most basically, metaphors are a conceptual building block of discourse. Lakoff and Johnson (1980) write that “(o)ur conceptual system...plays a central role in defining our everyday realities...the way we think, what we experience, and what we do every day is very much a matter of metaphor” (p. 3). Lakoff and Johnson’s (1980) landmark book, *Metaphors We Live By*, argued that our system of language uses metaphors to shape the way we think about almost everything. For example, they cite common metaphorical parlance such as “time is money” to demonstrate how phrases like “waste of time” depend on a complex system of metaphor to organize reality (p. 8). Rhetorically, metaphors create a “vocabulary of motives” that allow people to understand and shape how they make decisions (Ivie, 1974). Both Ivie and Lakoff and Johnson make the strong case that metaphors shape the way we understand the world. The use of a metaphor frames any situation in which it is used. For instance, in the “time is money” example the monetary framing of time means that we conceive of time as a commodity (1980, p. 8). Metaphors are extremely powerful in their ability to shape how rhetoric functions. Ivie and other have written about how “metaphors” have shaped policy discourse about the Cold War and other policy situations.

Analogical reasoning and metaphor are intimately related, Goodnight (2004) argues “(m)etaphors precede analogies because the act of comparison is a fusion of seeing one thing in terms of another, a move to apprehend that is opened up to testing by the pressure or temptation to render explicit what is grasped at once and as whole.” Analogies function similarly to metaphors by framing how we view both the given situation and the compared referent. A key distinction between the type of framing in metaphor and analogy is that analogy is almost always used purposefully. The referent in an analogy is intended to be used as a frame for the issue at hand; whereas in metaphor, the pervasiveness of metaphor in everyday language means that the framing inherent in metaphors is unconscious, while still significant.

Analogies are frequent in almost all types of writing. Deliberative analogies use analogical reasoning to make arguments about the future public policy decisions (given that deliberative rhetoric is concerned with similar subjects). Analogies in a deliberative context frame how the decision is made and thought about. Mary Stuckey (1992) argues that “(c)ertain events, like certain people and certain places, become symbols for actions and policy positions...these metaphors help to order political reality.” I would argue Stuckey’s understanding of “metaphor” is better understood as analogy: events stand in for other policy positions. Much in the same way that metaphors frame the world, analogies order the way political decisions are made.

Analogical reasoning in the public sphere can be counter-productive to deliberation if the referent is sufficiently distant from public knowledge that it can be easily distorted. Nietzsche warns against this way of using the past. As Euben (2003) explains, Nietzsche that idealization of the past “is a form of disengagement, of making them (the Greeks) decorative rather than allowing them to invigorate our political, cultural, or intellectual lives” (p. 8-9). Nietzsche, responding to some historicizing forces of his own time, labeled the kind of analogical reasoning I examine “monumentalizing.” Nietzsche (1997) argues “the monumental mode of regarding history rules over the other modes...the past itself suffers harm: whole segments of it are forgotten, despise and flow away in an uninterrupted colourless flood and only individualized embellished facts rise of out it like islands” (p. 70-71). The exclusion of events that Nietzsche describes here is significant because it demonstrates that historical thinking in this way is not instructive of what history actually is, but rather functions in the Burkean sense of a terministic screen. White (1987) makes a similar point arguing that “...exclusions consign to historical thinking the kinds of events that lend themselves to whatever currently passes for educated common sense. They effect a disciplining of the imagination...and set the limits on what constitutes a specifically historical event” (p. 66). Metaphorical/analogical thinking by its nature picks specific events and thus participates in this type of exclusion. The

metaphorical frames inherent in analogical reasoning are often more exclusive of actual understanding of history than they are illuminative.

Given that social knowledge is a key component of deliberation, the use of analogy for deliberation must be affected by and affects social knowledge. Because historical knowledge itself is not by nature a social knowledge (historians possess a particular kind of technical knowledge of the past), history cannot be thought of as simply another form of social knowledge. The discourses that historical texts produce, as explained by White and Barthes, derive authority from their very status. Social knowledge about the technical expertise of historians or about the “truth” of history allows these discourses to be self-referential in their claims to authority. My point is that what matters is not what history is about; the issue is the medium or form. History is “true” because it is history. Secondly, the metaphorical logic of historical deliberative analogy creates frames on reality that cause these analogies to include only what they find relevant and exclude any other historical knowledge. These inclusions and exclusions are particularly important in a deliberative context because as Lakoff and Johnson (1980) explain, metaphorical framing is fundamental to what is relevant to a deliberative context, which is to say they frame what we think of as reality as terministic screens.

David Noon (2004) reminds us that historical analogy is more about forgetting than remembering: “the very device that pretends to remind us of the past instead demands both unwitting and active forgetfulness... the ‘obvious’ feel offered by certain historical analogies means that it is not the past so much as its interpretation that repeats itself.” My argument, thus, is not anti-historical but rather a call for more responsible uses of the past. The oft-repeated adage that those who forget the past are doomed to repeat it might not be so useless after all. Yet, the method by which we choose to remember is vital to avoiding this repetition. Historicism is more likely to cause this kind of cycle than any other approach to history. White (1987) contributes to this argument saying that “nothing is better suited to lead to a repetition of the past than a study of it that is reverential or convincingly

objective” (p. 82). Historical deliberative analogy causes a more potent method of erasing the past because the analogy itself has a powerful myth-making function. The narrative enshrined by this kind of deliberation creates canonical interpretations of the past. In this way, historical deliberative analogy is counter-productive to effective public sphere deliberation.

Case Study: Victor Davis Hanson

Most examples in this case study are drawn from his 2002 book *An Autumn of War*, a compilation of Hanson’s editorial writing, mainly appearing in the *National Journal* between September 11, 2002 and December 22, 2002; a book that Bush and Cheney both read and recommended, according to the anecdotes, suggests that the text itself is a good example of writing by Hanson that may have influenced policy. The other selections, *A War Like No Other* and *Ripples of Battle* were critically acclaimed and widely read, further representing Hanson’s historical work.

These selections provide an overview that demonstrates how his work uses historical narrative and deliberative analogies. The essays in *An Autumn of War* are part of an ongoing debate in the United States about foreign policy, particularly after September 11th, 2001. Hanson’s editorials and historical accounts contributed to the deliberative voices being heard.

Furthermore, Hanson’s work is an instance when historical deliberative analogy may become counter-productive to oppositional argument in the public sphere. *An Autumn of War* demonstrates how social knowledge and technical knowledge meet in the public sphere in terms of history.

Finally, Hanson’s work is an excellent example of how historical narratives garner legitimation through their form, simply by being “historical.” I argue that Hanson’s framing of history allows his work to have a stronger authority in the public sphere than other voices. The third facet is Hanson’s use of universal ‘lessons’ of history that exhibits how public memory can be misused in the public sphere.

Most of Hanson’s discourse does not rely on social knowledge in the strict sense, in that his referents would not be

commonly known among a public audience. Hanson's discussion of the classics demonstrates the way in which he would like such history to be social knowledge and popular collective memory. Hanson's interest in reviving the classics is first located in one his most widely read books, *Who Killed Homer? The Demise of Classical Education and the Recovery of Greek Wisdom*. In the book, Hanson attempts to explain the lack of popularity and the demise of classical education in America. He concludes that we Americans should learn about classical history and use that knowledge to emulate the Greeks. Hanson (1998) writes:

The loss of Greek wisdom even as its material legacy is sweeping the planet is a tragic development – a story of corruption filled with irony. The Greeks gave us the tools to improve our material world... We need make no apology for seeing a unique moral lesson in Greek literature beyond 'text,' 'rhetoric,' and 'discourse,' for thinking the Greeks belong to those outside campus... (p. xviii)

The claim that we must use the "moral lesson(s)" of the Greeks in our lives is suspect. Nietzsche's (1997) argument that the use of classical history be "untimely" is useful here (p. 57) untimely in the sense that history should be outside our contemporary thinking. Hanson's own invocation of "Greek wisdom" in his political writings is a good example of what he might mean by lessons in Greek texts. This use of history is precisely the kind of universal lessons of the past that are problematic in the public sphere. It is paradoxical that Hanson perhaps knows best that his audience has no substantive knowledge of ancient history, but yet is prolific in his reference to the classics.

The monopolization of knowledge that is a result of the historical distance between the classics and a contemporary audience makes Hanson's writing unassailable. This usage is a perfect demonstration of how technical knowledge is used to garner authority. Public memory or public understanding of classical history is largely unavailable to assess his work. Furthermore, his status as a historian creates an impenetrable air of

authority in his analogies that allow his analogical reasoning to have powerful persuasive force. The simple use of “history as history” garners more authority for his claims as well, as Hayden White’s work reminds us. This legitimation is further amplified by the public’s complete lack of understanding of Greek and Roman history and culture (as demonstrated by *Who Killed Homer*). The implication is if Hanson’s audience is the general public, his work is either not persuasive because they cannot understand the referents or that it is persuasive because his use of classical history legitimates his authority precisely because it is history.

But who is Hanson’s audience? The popularity of *An Autumn of War* should not be understated. Hanson’s subsequent book received a \$500,000 advance from his publisher, a massive figure that demonstrates the widespread popularity of his work (Holland, 2005). Hanson is also a regular contributor to the widely circulated *National Review*. Given this, it’s fair to surmise that Hanson is at least read modestly by the American public, if not on a wide scale. The popularity of his works was put well by Publisher’s Weekly which argues: “Hanson may succeed the late Stephen Ambrose as America’s laureate of military history” (2003). Euben (2005) argues that Hanson’s work has led a movement for a thorough consideration on Thucydides in policy deliberation (p. 5). As Euben notes, the other important audience for the book, *Autumn of War* is the neo-conservative faction at the White House. The book was published shortly before the invasion of Iraq in 2002. It is interesting to note that Dick Cheney read the book, according to a number of accounts and reportedly told his staff “that it encapsulated his tough-guy philosophy” (Gewen, 2003). Maureen Dowd (2003) dubbed Hanson “Cheney’s war guru.” Given this, the audience for the work is both the general public and those in positions of power. The implication is that Hanson’s writing is significant in terms of its effect on public policy.

In the summer of 2001, Hanson published *Carnage and Culture*, a book about the importance of leadership in times of crisis. Hanson and the book garnered attention from the national media after September 11th due to the relevance of the book’s

thesis (Tempest, 2004). Hanson then began writing for the *National Review* and those articles were then compiled into *An Autumn of War*. After the success of his book *Carnage and Culture*, Hanson's credibility as a historian allowed him to write with authority on classical subjects, and the seeming relevance of classical history to the contemporary crisis gave him authority to write about contemporary events.

Collective memory studies also provide insight into the process by which Hanson's classical history becomes persuasive knowledge. Classical memory is so far removed from any personal particular memories of his audience; Hanson's arguments are made persuasive by the sheer remoteness, the "pastness" of his arguments. But, Hanson's technical authority is enhanced by his knowledge of the classics, amplified by the fact that few people knew much about them except that they were a long time ago and were somehow related to the Greeks. Hanson's use of classical history in the above and following examples demonstrates this. To a typical American audience, classics seem like a super-specialized type of discourse, because they are so remote. I would liken this to the type of knowledge a neurological surgeon would have. The extreme specialization and training of the surgeon would legitimate almost anything they said on the subject. Hanson is the brain surgeon of history because he's talking about Greek history.

Legitimation in history is gained in many ways for Hanson. Consider this example of historical narration as Hanson (2003) presents his argument that war is an inherent part of the world:

At the universities, throughout the national media, in our suburbs-and perhaps, unfortunately, inside the State Department- there are very dangerous ideas floating around about Mr. bin Laden and this present war. We would do well to cast them aside and look to our past. War for most of the past twenty-five hundred years of Western Civilization was seen as a tragedy innate to the human condition ... Wars were a sort of acquisition... Bullies, whether out of vanity or a desire for power and recognition, took things from other people unless they

were stopped. And if they were to be halted, citizens – among them good, kind, and well-read men like Socrates, Sophocles, Thucydides, and Demosthenes – fought to protect their freedom and to save the innocent... (p. 64)

Hanson's criticism of the anti-war movement is that they oppose all war despite any redeeming circumstances. His main argument for war as a defense against "bullies" could easily be turned on its head when thinking about imperial Athens as a "bully." It is at best dubious to think that imperial Athens was simply defending against petty aggressors. But here Hanson cites no evidence for his claims, rather just making assertions based in suspect generalizations about Greek history. This demonstrates the circularity of his use of the past – he can draw on almost any example from classical history, frame it as a justification and move on.

The most bizarre of the essays in *An Autumn of War* is titled "A Voice from the Past" in which Hanson makes up a fictional conversation with Thucydides. Hanson poses questions about the War in Iraq and other contemporary political situations and then chooses quotes from Thucydides as answers. This piece is simply baffling, given that the quotes are mainly out of context and cryptic "answers" at best. Yet, this article provides another stylistic device that Hanson uses, drawing upon direct quotes from classical literature, in bizarre way. This particular question and answer comes from the middle of the conversation:

Question: But, General, you must concede that after Vietnam and now the disaster in New York, there is a growing fear that we might not prevail, but instead provoke even greater terror. The Taliban sounded pretty dangerous, after all, and there's still Iraq and all the rest.

Thucydides: One must confront enemies not merely with spirit but with disdain. Confidence-indeed a blissful ignorance-can reside even in a coward's breast, but disdain is the privilege of those who, like us, have been assured by reflection of their superiority to their

adversary. More the chances of war are the same; knowledge fortifies courage by the contempt that is its consequence... [2.631] (2003, p. 146-147)

The “answer” comes from Pericles’ first speech urging the Athenians to go to war. It’s hard to surmise just how Hanson came up with this response or any in the editorial, but my best guess is that he opened Thucydides at a random page and pointed. Again, this demonstrates how Hanson can use almost any part of classical history as a justification for his viewpoints regardless of their actual applicability. The entire idea of asking Thucydides seems similar to the mystical augury of the *sortes virgilae*. Sir Phillip Sidney’s (1595) Elizabethan work gives a description of this practice in “*The Defence of Poesie*.” Sidney describes a type of poet-prophet who took the work of Virgil and opened it to a page and verse and subsequently used that verse to make a prediction about the future.¹ Hanson is performing his own sort of *Sortes Thucydideae*, relying again on the mythical quality of classical history. In Hanson’s view, we can arbitrarily choose some selections from the great authors to guide current policy. History is not only realistically mythical; it is also prophetic for Hanson.

The legitimization of Hanson’s arguments from his pseudo-social knowledge and from his historical discourse both contribute to how his use of deliberative analogies functions. Analogical thinking depends on the comparison between two events and as Burke (1984) puts it “similarity is taken as evidence of identity” (p. 97). Here is typical Hanson (2003) passage that demonstrates this type of argument:

The destruction of the World Trade Center, the downing of four airliners, and the ravaging of the Pentagon.... Thousands of our countrymen are dead; we accept that the world can never be quite what it was... Like the Greek city-states in the path of Xerxes' terror, or Athens in the shadow of Macedon, they wonder whether there is an escape from the ordeal ahead, through moderation and

¹ This practice is also done with other great works such as the Bible etc

conciliation. There is none ... Salamis, not envoys and ambassadors, halted Xerxes. (p. 43)

Here Hanson makes an analogy between September 11th and the Persian war. The article in which this example was found was originally published on September 26, 2001. Zerubavel's (1994) point that when there is social disruption societies seek to "restructure the past... to its future agenda" amplifies this point (p. 105). Hanson's use of analogical reasoning and calling upon the past is particularly poignant after September 11th because there is a need for identification, something to explain the tragedy. Analogical thinking creates parallels that allow these identifications to become significant and rhetorical. The argument here displays the persuasive power of analogical reasoning.

Hanson's analogical arguments also consistently rely on great people or events to provide referents and identification. Nietzsche (1997) describes monumental history this way: "the great moments in history in the struggles of the human individual constitute a chain, that this chain unites mankind across the millennia like a range of human mountain peaks..." (p. 68). For Nietzsche, this kind of monumental history, which is clearly similar to analogical thinking, damages historical knowledge because of its selectivity. Hanson's work is an exemplar of this kind of monumental history because he parses out great events and persons as valuable to the present. The following exemplifies this point:

In this classical paradigm, the present crisis, I think, looks something like this: The United States, being a strong and wealthy society, invites envy because of the success of its restless culture of freedom, democracy, self-critique, secular rationalism, and open markets... If, like the Athenians, we butcher neutral Melians for no good cause, then our war is evil and we should lose. But if we fight to preserve freedom like the Greeks at Thermopylae and the GIs at Normandy Beach, then war is the right and indeed the only thing we can do. (2003, p. 65-66)

The paradigmatic view of history Hanson advocates here is certainly parallel to monumentalizing, or setting up the past as a

guide to the present. The use of analogy immediately following demonstrates how monumental history calls for analogical reasoning. This kind of monumental history is not about actual education regarding the past, but rather is about forgetting the past; it sees universally aggrandized figures. Hanson's analogy proves this point: the Athenians killing Melians is only evil while the defense at Thermopylae is only good. This is not to say that such a claim is false, but Hanson seeks to derive one universal understanding of each side in battle, without really explaining either.

Hanson's use of deliberative analogy displays a number of characteristics that make them less contestable than other facets of public discourse. Consider the following as a final example:

We in the United States have suffered a great loss. But the incineration of innocent civilians in our cities was not due to our intrinsic weaknesses but rather, like the Greeks in the weeks before Thermopylae, attributable to our naiveté and unpreparedness. The bloody wages of this ignorance of the power of a free people aroused are age-old and unmistakable -Xerxes's sixty thousand washed ashore at Salamis... Western nations at war, from the Greeks to the present, are not weak but enormously lethal-far out of proportion to their relatively small population and territory. This power is not an accident of geography, much less attributable to natural resources or genes, but rather found in its very ideas and values. The foundations of Western culture-freedom, civic militarism, capitalism, individualism, constitutional government, and secular rationalism-when applied to the battlefield have always resulted in carnage for their adversaries (2003, p. 6).

Here Hanson writes in his typical straightforward style, arguing that the "West" will defeat terrorism because of its superiority. This article was written on September 12th and published on September 26th, 2001 according to the book. The timing is key because it demonstrates how Hanson was able to manipulate his immense knowledge of classics to make arguments that were directly relevant to the emerging debate about whether or

not to retaliate. The technical knowledge he employs here gives his argument the authority capable of intimidating a typical reader. His use of the narrativizing account that all of Western history proves Western superiority draws a line from the past to the present that provides a mythic quality to his argument. His historical account must be correct simply by virtue of the fact that it references remote history. The referent, Salamis, is not a battle that the audience would be familiar with and as such makes the collective memory he references static and not open to debate. The whole argument centers around universal qualities of Western culture such as “freedom”; these universals mean that the knowledge is not generative. All of these factors combine to make this argument bullet-proof to public debate and deliberation.

Conclusion

There are those that hold up the use of analogy in deliberation. For example, Goodnight argues for the use of deliberative analogical reasoning in the public sphere in an essay entitled “Iraq is George Bush’s Vietnam.” His argument centers on particular deliberative analogies that are able to “challenge” common assumptions about policy choices. Based on the work of Lakoff and Johnson, Goodnight (2004) argues that analogies can contest a metaphor in public debate “comparisons with the past will be made and contested because such likenesses offer powerful frames of references, fields of invention, avenues of interpretation, and grounds for contesting legitimacy.” For Goodnight, deliberative analogies open up space for “controversy” in the public sphere. Goodnight’s work on the subject are found in three articles that consider the case studies of Reagan’s policy debates about Central America, Clinton and Haiti, and more recent debates on Iraq. He presents this description of the function of deliberative analogy in his Iraq article:

- (1) *Claim: A known case X should inform the uncertain case Y*
- (2) *Warrant: Because in telling respects case X is like case Y*

(3) *Exception: Because only in circumstantial respects is case X different than case Y*

(4) *Why? Grounding in literal, resonant, principled or reflexive comparison.*

A deliberative analogy multiplies the inventive space for argument because when invoked, not only are the issues related to the present case under discussion debatable (Y), but also the nature of case (X) as well as its continuing relevance to (Y) are put under discussion.
(2004)

Goodnight's main point is that the memory of the past among the public allows contestation to become more viable and contestable in the case of historical analogies. While Goodnight's argument is sound, the questions advanced in this chapter about technical knowledge and authority present some challenges to the general applicability of historical analogy in public sphere deliberation.

Goodnight (1996) further argues in the context of Reagan and Central America that "The contested historical narratives undermined the grounds for common discussion, fragmented consensus, and expanded the scope and stakes of partisan opposition" (p. 151). This seeming contradiction between Goodnight's two arguments about analogy demonstrates simply that all deliberative analogy is not equal. Goodnight here presents a key argument that can be used against the use of historical deliberative analogy, that policy deliberation on the meaning of history can be counter-productive when the sides do not approach history from an equal standing. The problem being, of course, that given history's tendency to create legitimation based on narratives that support ideological ends, analogies most often are present when the opposing sides do not have equal access to those narratives.

There are further conditions that limit the contestability of deliberative analogy, including its ability to be truly *deliberative*. First, history is not an avenue for interpretation that is open widely to the public; it is fundamentally a technical type of argument. History can be accessible to most, but not the type of history used

in deliberative analogy that is highly specific and policy based, such as Hanson's usage. Secondly, Goodnight's argument assumes that deliberation on the terms of history being presented is open to the public. Given the form of most policy discussions, particularly those he cites which are mainly debates about presidential policies, public deliberation is not likely to focus on whether the historical referent is adequate but rather whether the conclusion is relevant. Historical analogy is more likely to be used by a speaker in power rather than by those who are contesting legitimacy, because history is more effective in reinforcing the status quo.

Goodnight's claim that analogy allows oppositional debate only works for one side of the debate, those already possessing power and not those in resistant positions. The discursive function of history as a narrative explains how these historical referents are given legitimacy in the public sphere. Self-referential history creates its own authority, and because it is inherently laden with ideology it is not the most effective means for people trying to contest power relationships. More effective resistance would be a discourse, according to White (1966), which emphasizes "discontinuity, disruption, and chaos" in how we connect to the past (p. 166).

History and analogy are inevitable and will continue to be used in American policy discussions and in the public sphere for as long as there is a public sphere. The question is, what is a productive use of deliberative analogy and how do we get there? While the conclusions, simply judging from Hanson's work, might not be all too encouraging, I believe there is a possibility for deliberative uses of history that can as Goodnight (2004) hopes "offer powerful frames of reference...and grounds for contesting legitimacy" (p. 8). History is an essential constituent of what forms social knowledge and is used rhetorically. Understanding the tensions between technical history and how it is deployed in the public sphere is necessary to appropriately include deliberative analogy as a means for contesting legitimacy.

The view of deliberative analogy offered by Goodnight views the practice as the main productive in the public sphere for allowing debate and discussion. Goodnight does provide a number

of conditions. In his discussion of Reagan and Central American crises Goodnight (1996) maintained that the use of historical analogy was handicapped by the differing frames the Left and Right used in the debate, namely that the Right used history to validate the status quo and the Left unsuccessfully tried to contextualize the Right's revisionism. The ideal deliberative analogy that would allow for Goodnight's concept of open contestation would include extensive discussion of the historical case. Hanson's prolific use of historical analogy and its importance in the debate about Iraq demonstrate another case of the complexity of deliberative analogy.

Hanson's work demonstrates a few other conditions that are necessary to allow contestation to happen in the public sphere with deliberative analogy. First, the authority of the advocate must be considered. As a historian, Hanson's arguments from history allow his use of historical referents to have more value than others. The form that they take also enhances the validity of Hanson's arguments. The narrative frame of history promotes a mythologized history that Goodnight would seek to avoid. Hanson's authority as a specialist crowds out oppositional argument. Secondly, Hanson's arguments are largely based in classical history, of which the collective memory is almost non-existent. Collective memory of the classics is mainly formed through vague generalizations. The lessons of the classics view that Hanson employs allow his arguments to be legitimated both because no one in the public knows about what he talks and also because distanced Roman and Greek histories are seen as unquestionable. This demonstrates that deliberative analogies should also include pasts that are known by the public. Farrell's understanding of social knowledge as "consensus driven" should underwrite this. For social knowledge to generate discussion people have to have some common knowledge. These exceptions to Goodnight's ideal deliberative analogy suggest that a more nuanced view of history is necessary to make analogical reasoning a productive terrain for public debate.

Hayden White and others have demonstrated the dangers of using history as an ideological storehouse from which we draw

out conclusions about the present. Understanding history is certainly an important endeavor for the public and policy makers alike, but the use of history characterized by Hanson is counter-productive. Hanson's use of classical history is not about educating the public using some understanding of the classics, but rather is a particular framing of collective memory that is aimed at forgetting the larger scope of classical history. When Hanson isolates ideological lessons from Thucydides, for example, we are unable to see the larger context and polyphony of voices that exist in classical history, and in any type of history. David Noon's (2004) observation about historical analogy deserves repeating "it is not the past as much as its interpretation that repeats itself." Thus, Hanson's assertion that we should listen to "Greek wisdom" in the process of learning about history becomes self-serving. Hanson's use of deliberative analogy is more about justifying conservative political positions than reinvigorating classical education in the United States.

How can students and critics read and understand history, particular classical history, in way that avoids these pitfalls? Should classical history never be invoked in policy debates? If there is no movement towards a more thorough education of the general public in terms of the classics, using the classics in deliberative contexts will inevitability lead us to these same problems. Thus, classical education is an imperative, not only because it is foundational for much of our culture, but also because it will likely continue to be used in the Hanson manner. In the absence of common understanding of classical history, deliberative analogies employing the classics serve only to reinforce canonical views of history and cause the public to forget that there are other voices. We should listen instead to the polyphony of history. Nietzsche called this view of history "untimely," that is having a healthy understanding of the past but abstaining from using the past only to inform the present. Engaging with classical history allows informed deliberation to occur in public discussion. A public with an understanding of classical history would contest representation and references to classical history. The problem, of course, is that this formulation may be unattainable on a broad

scale. When deliberative analogy is potentially a viable method with which to challenge some policy positions, as Goodnight has argued, there is the danger that Hanson and others will abuse these formulations. Thus, critical audiences should remain attentive to the conditions under which deliberative analogy is deployed particularly when the referent is distantly historical.

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